

# Why I Started The Potter's House Relief Fund

*By Duane Darden, Executive Director and Founder*

## The Vision of The Potter's House

When seeking a name and a guiding philosophy for this organization, I looked to the biblical meaning of the Potter's House, found in the Book of Jeremiah (Jeremiah 18:1–6). In the scripture, the prophet visits a potter working with clay on a wheel. When the clay becomes marred or damaged in the potter's hands, he does not throw it away in frustration. Instead, he patiently reshapes and molds it into a new vessel, one with purpose and value.

At The Potter's House Relief Fund (PHRF), our youth are that clay. Many of the teenagers we serve have been marred by trauma, poverty, or circumstances they could not control. But we do not discard them. Through the National Youth Network, we serve as the potter's hands, gently but firmly shaping and molding these young people into outstanding, productive adults who know their worth.

***Enter Duane Darden, that clay.***

I know exactly what it feels like to have no one in your corner. I was that kid.

I spent the first years of my life, from birth until I was two or three years old, in an orphanage. My mother was just fifteen when she had me, and her staunchly Catholic father did not support her decision to bring me home. I was caught in the middle of decisions I had absolutely no say in. Learning that story as an adult planted a profound realization within me: a child's future can be either shaped or broken by forces completely outside of their control. Just like the clay at the Potter's House.

## From Brokenness to the Wheel

I understand the breaking process because I lived it. When I finally came home from the orphanage, after TWO stays, life did not magically get easier. These were my ODDS:

1. **A Turbulent Home:** I grew up in a household where violence was routine. It caused me to run away, and I was eventually removed from my home.
2. **The Wrong Crowd:** Craving the love, recognition, and empathy I wasn't getting at home, I found acceptance with people who celebrated my worst instincts. Breaking into cars and homes became my escape.
3. **A Mythological Father:** After making me the second oldest of 29 children, my father was absent, broke, abusive, dishonest, and a thief. I thank him for only one thing: his example was so destructive that it made me fiercely determined not to pass any of it down to my own children.
4. **My Mother:** Probably broken herself. She was just a child when she had me.

My bad decisions eventually caught up with me. I spent 14 months in a juvenile facility after being charged with assault, criminal damaging, and aggravated burglary. Sitting in

that detention center, I made a life-altering decision: jail was not going to be my story. I chose a different path, and I never looked back.

After an explosive situation at home, I left at fifteen, forced to build something out of nothing. I know what it means to not have. I know what it means to be alone.

## **Shaping the Future: The National Youth Network**

My upbringing did not break me. It became the foundation of everything I believe about what teenagers are capable of when someone simply believes in them. I did not start this organization because I read a statistic. I started it because I lived the story.

The difference between a young person who makes it and one who falls through the cracks is often just one adult, one opportunity, one moment where someone says, "I see you, and I am not leaving." The National Youth Network exists to make sure that moment is a guarantee, not a matter of luck.

We work with teens ages 13 to 17 across Ohio, Kentucky, and Georgia, providing the tools they need to mold their own futures. Cincinnati, Ohio is where my personal story began, but the youth we serve across all three states are navigating the exact same uncertain world.

To shape and mold our youth, we provide comprehensive wrap-around services:

**Emergency Financial Relief:** Stabilizing families in crisis.

**Job Training and Mentoring:** Equipping teens with the skills and guidance needed for productive adulthood.

**Academic Support and Youth Development:** Because stability and opportunity must always go hand in hand.

## **Join Us in the Work**

I am not running this organization from the outside looking in. I am running it from the inside out, because I was that teenager. Every single young person we serve deserves to have someone in their corner who truly cares about the battles they are facing.

If you believe that every teenager deserves the chance to be reshaped, molded, and empowered to create their own future, rather than waiting for someone to hand it to them, then you belong with us.

**JOIN US.... PLEASE**